Conceptualising Inclusive Access: Lessons and Critical Reflections on the Challenges of Access to Digital Archives and Collections

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Conceptualisations of open and inclusive access must be informed by plural, heterogeneous and contextual meanings of access. I argue that studying challenges of access to digital archives and collections can help conceptualising frameworks for inclusive access. This is important, especially in light of the renewed emphasis on building open infrastructure (Budapest Open Access Initiative 2022). This paper highlights the necessity of building a nuanced understanding of access by examining firstly, discourses surrounding access to digital archives, and secondly, by focussing on collection and dissemination practices of community digital archives, which feature varied and graded levels of access. These reflections are carried out through methods of cultural studies and historical method, website and news articles online, and personal experience of accessing these archives as researcher positionality. It also includes insights from discussions and consultations with diverse archival professionals and initiatives attempting to build access to GLAM sector data held during the Stories on Contested Histories International Programme in Amsterdam in 2024.

In 2022, celebrating its 20th anniversary, the Budapest Open Access Initiative laid out recommendations for the next ten years, key among which is building open infrastructure. This makes it all the more crucial to understand and remember that openness and privacy mean different things in different communities and locations. Digitisation is not equivalent to access (Zaagsma 2023), and putting everything online is not meaningful access; it can actually replicate existing harms. As we archive, particularly in digital formats, these questions of openness and access emerge as crucial ethical dilemmas. This foregrounds an important question: *Who are we building access for?* It requires us to consider what meaningful access means to those communities. As we archive in a digital age, these questions around access form crucial ethical dilemmas.

When examining initiatives aimed at increasing access to digital archival collections, it becomes clear that challenges to access are not merely technical or economic issues, nor simply matters of resource allocation, digitization, or funding to make archives public. The challenges of building inclusive access also stem from an inadequate understanding of access itself. The meaning of access needs to be understood as multiple, varied, and contextual, taking into account the realities of colonialism, materialism, and postcolonialism (Risam 2018). To avoid Eurocentric or occidental conceptions of inclusive access can be developed through frameworks that address the challenges and lessons learned from access issues in digital archives. Principles of openness and access, if they are informed by singular, homogenous understanding of access to information, will remain inadequate. Knowledge frameworks need to be respectful, cognizant of varying knowledge systems, so that they do not continue to perpetuate epistemic hegemony that has historically disprivileged communities and regions.

This paper highlights how access is built and negotiated in various forms of digital archives, particularly indigenous, community-based, and crowdsourced citizen-created collections, and reflects on the challenges and opportunities for meaningful access in these contexts. Digital archives of community memories especially are analyzed as both public humanities and digital humanities projects, highlighting their role in fostering engagement with diverse publics. Drawing on Judith Butler's and Susan Smulyan's reflections on Public Humanities (Butler 2022; Smulyan 2022), the paper underscores that publics are not monolithic but multifaceted, shaped by location, context, and lived historical experiences, and extends these insights to discussions on building inclusive and nuanced understanding of access.

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